Coaching Codex



COACHING CODEX · GUIDE 03 · AI FOR CUSTOMER SUPPORT

Automate Your Inbox and Customer Replies with AI

Sort, draft and automate emails, WhatsApp and DMs, so customers get fast, friendly answers and you get your time back. You stay in control.

5 steps
a simple inbox system

3 levels
no-tech, built-in, no-code

7 days
rollout plan + safety rules

START HERE

Answer customers faster, without becoming a robot.

Emails, WhatsApp messages, Instagram DMs, website chats: customer messages arrive everywhere and never stop. This guide shows you how to use AI and simple automation to sort, draft and send replies faster, while you stay in control of every answer that matters.

The 5-step Inbox System you'll build

1 · SORT
Know what arrives and group it into a few clear types

▶

2 · REPLY LIBRARY
Ready answers for your most common questions

▶

3 · AI DRAFTS
AI writes first drafts; you check and send

▶

4 · AUTOMATE
Rules and no-code tools do the repetitive steps

▶

5 · REVIEW
Weekly check: speed, quality, what to improve

Level 1 · No tech

Reply library + AI chat assistant. Start today, any email app.

Level 2 · Built-in

Filters, labels, templates and AI features already in Gmail, Outlook and WhatsApp Business.

Level 3 · Automated

Zapier, Make or n8n create AI drafts automatically for you to approve.

THE GOLDEN RULE

AI drafts, a human decides. Start with AI preparing drafts that you review. Only let replies send automatically for simple, low-risk messages (like opening hours), and only after you've tested them for a few weeks.

What's inside

01 Audit your inbox · 02 Build your reply library p. 3–4

03 AI-drafted replies · 04 Built-in email features p. 5–6

05 No-code automation · 06 Chats & DMs p. 7–8

07 Safety rules · 08 7-day rollout plan p. 9–10

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STEP 1 · SORT

Audit your inbox in 20 minutes

You can't automate what you haven't looked at. Scroll through your last 50 customer messages and tally them into types. Most small businesses find a handful of types make up most of their messages.

Message type	Example	Count (tally)	Could be a template?
Price / quote question	"How much for…?"		
Availability / booking	"Do you have a slot on Friday?"		
Order or delivery status	"Where is my order?"		
Product / service question	"Does it come in blue?"		
Complaint / problem	"It arrived damaged."		
Refund / change request	"Can I cancel?"		
Supplier / partner / admin	Invoices, offers, newsletters		
Spam / not relevant	Sales pitches, promos		

PROMPT · CLASSIFY MY MESSAGES

I'm going to paste [NUMBER] customer messages with names and personal details removed.
Group them into 5–8 types. For each type show: a name, how many messages, one typical example, and whether a standard reply could handle it (yes / partly / no).
Present it as a table, sorted from most to least common.
[PASTE MESSAGES]

EXERCISE 1 · YOUR TOP 3

Write the three message types that take most of your time. These are the first ones you'll speed up.

1. _____ **2.** _____ **3.** _____

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STEP 2 · REPLY LIBRARY

Build your reply library and “Business Facts” sheet

A reply library is a set of ready answers for your common message types. Your Business Facts sheet is the source of truth the AI uses, so it doesn’t make things up.

Your Business Facts sheet (fill in once, update monthly)

Topic	Your facts
Opening hours & contact channels	
Prices / packages (or where to find them)	
Delivery / turnaround times	
Refund, exchange & cancellation policy	
Booking / ordering steps	
What you don’t do (so AI won’t promise it)	

PROMPT · GENERATE MY REPLY LIBRARY

[PASTE BUSINESS FACTS SHEET]
Using only these facts, write a reply template for each of these message types: [YOUR TOP MESSAGE TYPES].
For each template: a short subject line, a friendly reply under 90 words, [BRACKETS] for details I fill in each time, and a one-line note on when NOT to use it.
If a fact is missing, write [ASK OWNER] instead of guessing.

WHERE TO KEEP IT

Save templates where you reply: Gmail **Templates**, Outlook **My Templates** or **Quick Parts**, WhatsApp Business **Quick Replies**, and saved replies in Meta Business Suite for Facebook and Instagram. A shared document works too.

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STEP 3 · AI DRAFTS

Let AI write the first draft of every reply

For messages that don't fit a template, use one master prompt. Keep a chat open with your Business Facts already pasted in, then just add each new message.

MASTER PROMPT · CUSTOMER REPLY ASSISTANT

You are the customer service assistant for **[BUSINESS]**. Use only these facts: **[PASTE BUSINESS FACTS]**.
Tone: **[e.g. warm, clear, professional]**. Write like a helpful person, not a corporation.
For each message I paste:
1. Tell me in one line what the customer wants and how they feel.
2. Write a reply under 120 words that answers clearly and gives one next step.
3. Flag anything you are unsure about with **[CHECK]**.
4. If the message is a complaint, legal issue, or mentions safety or health, write "ESCALATE" and do not draft a final answer.

The tone ladder

Situation	Tone to ask for	Add to the prompt
Simple question	Friendly & brief	"Answer in 2–3 sentences."
Unhappy customer	Calm, warm, accountable	"Acknowledge feelings first, no excuses."
Late payment / boundary	Polite but firm	"Clear deadline, no apology for asking."
VIP or big client	Personal & proactive	"Offer one extra helpful idea."

EXERCISE 2 · THREE HARD REPLIES

Find three messages you found hard to answer recently. Run each through the master prompt (with personal details removed). Compare with what you actually sent. Which reply would you rather receive?

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STEP 4 · BUILT-IN FEATURES

Use what your email app already does

Before buying anything new, switch on the free sorting tools in your email app. Menu names change from time to time; search your app's help for the feature name if you can't find it.

Goal	Gmail	Outlook
Auto-sort messages	Filters + Labels	Rules + Folders / Categories
Reusable replies	Templates (turn on in settings)	My Templates / Quick Parts
Focus on what matters	Priority or Important-first inbox	Focused Inbox
Snooze for later	Snooze	Snooze / Flag with reminder
Out-of-hours reply	Vacation responder	Automatic replies
AI help writing	Gemini features (depends on plan)	Copilot features (depends on plan)

Set up three filters/rules today

1. **Customers first:** messages that contain words like "order", "booking" or "quote" get a "Customers" label/folder and stay in the inbox.
2. **Admin later:** invoices, receipts and supplier updates skip the inbox into an "Admin" label/folder you check once a day.
3. **Newsletters out:** promotional mail goes to a "Read later" label/folder.

PROMPT · SET UP MY FILTERS

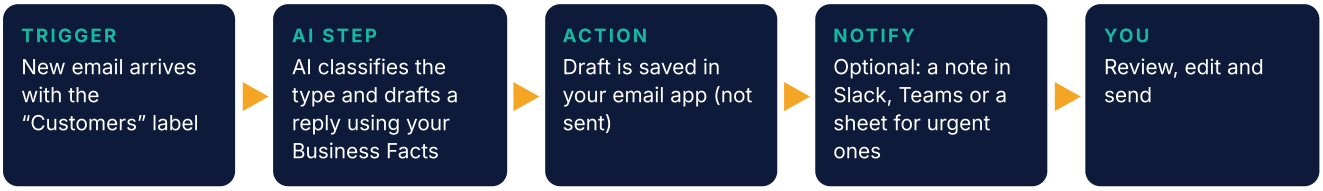
I use **[GMAIL / OUTLOOK]**. Give me step-by-step instructions, in plain words, to create a filter/rule that **[WHAT YOU WANT, e.g. labels emails containing 'invoice' as Admin and skips the inbox]**. Tell me which words to use and how to test it safely.

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STEP 5 · AUTOMATE

No-code automation: AI drafts waiting for you

No-code tools like **Zapier**, **Make** or **n8n** connect your apps with simple “when this happens, do that” recipes. This one prepares an AI draft for every new customer email, so you only review and send.



Build the recipe, step by step

1. Create an account with one automation tool (most offer a free plan or trial; check current limits).
2. Choose the trigger: your email app → “new email matching label / folder”.
3. Add an AI step (the tool’s built-in AI action or a connection to an AI provider) and paste the master reply prompt from Step 3.
4. Add an action: “create draft reply” in Gmail or Outlook. Do **not** choose “send”.
5. Optional: if the AI writes “ESCALATE”, send yourself an alert instead of a draft.
6. Test with 5 sample emails sent from your own personal address. Check every draft.
7. Turn it on and review all drafts for at least two weeks before trusting it more.

PROMPT · FOR THE AI STEP INSIDE YOUR AUTOMATION

You help [BUSINESS] answer customer emails. Facts: [PASTE BUSINESS FACTS].
Read the email below. Reply in exactly this format:
TYPE: one of [YOUR MESSAGE TYPES]
URGENCY: low / medium / high
ESCALATE: yes or no (yes for complaints, refunds, legal, safety or anything unclear)
DRAFT: a friendly reply under 120 words, or leave empty if ESCALATE is yes.
Email: [EMAIL BODY FROM THE TRIGGER]

READY-MADE TEMPLATES

Search your automation tool’s template gallery for “AI email reply draft” or “classify emails with AI”. Starting from a template is usually faster than building from scratch.

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STEP 6 · CHATS & DMS

WhatsApp, Instagram, Facebook & website chat

Many customers prefer chat to email. The same reply library works here; you just store it in different places.

Channel	Free built-in tools to switch on	How AI helps
WhatsApp Business app	Greeting message, away message, quick replies, labels, catalog	Write your quick replies and greeting from your reply library
Instagram & Facebook	Saved replies, FAQs and instant replies in Meta Business Suite	Generate FAQ answers and saved replies in your tone
Website chat	Chat widgets with FAQ or AI answer features (many website builders offer one)	Turn your Business Facts into an FAQ the widget can use
Phone / voicemail	Voicemail greeting, call-back hours	Script a short, clear greeting with next steps

PROMPT · CHAT FAQ + GREETING + AWAY MESSAGE

[PASTE BUSINESS FACTS]
Create a chat FAQ for [CHANNEL]. Give me 12 questions customers are likely to ask and an answer for each in max 2 short sentences, friendly and clear.
Then write: a greeting message, an away message for outside [OPENING HOURS], and a hand-over line for when a human needs to take over.

EXERCISE 3 · SWITCH ON TWO CHAT TOOLS

Today, turn on a **greeting** and an **away message** on your busiest chat channel, using text the AI drafted and you edited. Ask a friend to message you to test both.

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SECTION 07 · SAFETY RULES

Guardrails: protect your customers and your reputation

Automation multiplies whatever you set up, the good and the bad. These rules keep you safe.

Privacy checklist

- [ ] Remove names, phone numbers, addresses and IDs before pasting into a chat assistant
- [ ] Never paste passwords, card numbers or bank details
- [ ] Check each tool's data and privacy settings; use business plans where data handling is clearer
- [ ] Tell customers in your privacy notice if you use AI to help answer messages
- [ ] Follow the data protection rules that apply to you (e.g. GDPR for UK/EU customers, state privacy laws in the US)
- [ ] Give access only to the people and apps that need it

Always escalate to a human

- [ ] Complaints and angry customers
- [ ] Refunds above a limit you set
- [ ] Anything legal, medical, safety or financial advice
- [ ] Messages about staff, harassment or emergencies
- [ ] Your biggest clients
- [ ] Anything where the AI wrote [CHECK] or ESCALATE

NEVER FULLY AUTOMATE

Promises (prices, dates, refunds), apologies for serious problems, and anything that creates a legal commitment. AI can draft them; a person should approve them.

Quick quality check for every AI reply

- [ ] Answers the actual question
- [ ] Facts match your Business Facts sheet
- [ ] Tone fits the situation
- [ ] Has one clear next step
- [ ] You'd be comfortable if it were posted publicly

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SECTION 08 · ROLLOUT

Your 7-day rollout plan & weekly tracker

Small steps, one per day. By the end of the week you'll have a working system.

Day	Action	Time (est.)	Done
1	Audit last 50 messages, find your top 3 types	20 min	
2	Fill in your Business Facts sheet	20 min	
3	Generate and edit your reply library; save as templates	30 min	
4	Set up 3 email filters/rules	15 min	
5	Switch on chat greeting, away message and quick replies	20 min	
6	Use the master reply prompt for all non-template messages	Ongoing	
7	Optional: build the no-code draft automation and test it	45–60 min	

Times are rough estimates and depend on your message volume and tools.

Weekly tracker: see your progress

Week	Messages handled	Typical reply time	Templates used	Escalations	One thing to improve
1					
2					
3					
4					

PROMPT · WEEKLY REVIEW

Here are my notes from this week: [MESSAGES, PROBLEMS, CUSTOMER QUESTIONS].
Suggest: 3 new templates I should add, 1 template to improve, and 1 automation step worth trying next week.

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WHAT'S NEXT

Your inbox is under control. Ready for the next system?

You've built your first AI-powered workflow. The same ideas (facts, templates, AI drafts, a human check) work across your whole business.

No-Code Automation Starter Kit

Your first five automations with tools like Zapier, Make or n8n, explained step by step.

AI Agents & Connectors, Explained Simply

What AI agents and MCP connectors are, and when a small business should use them.

Write a Week of Social Media Posts in 30 Minutes with AI

Plan, write and schedule seven posts in one sitting.

AI Safety & Privacy for Small Businesses

Simple rules for using AI tools without risking customer trust.

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Tell us your result

How much faster are your replies after a month? Share your result; reader stories help us improve every guide.

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